like time of day, workflow state, or operational status—but were not broad enough to be foundational. For example, the after-hours deployment rule from section 15.3.2 is automatically enforced whenever a deployment request is evaluated; the policy engine does not care which pipeline initiated the request, only whether the operational conditions specified by engineering are met. An application's own policies may specify who can deploy or which environments are available, but the shared operational layer adjusts that logic to align with the broader rules guiding how engineering teams operate. This structure provides organizations with flexibility without requiring each team to hard-code operational requirements into every tool or service.

Application policies provided the final layer of decision-making. These policies articulated the business logic of each service, specifying which principals could access specific resources and under what conditions. For example, the finance reporting policies from section 15.3.3 define who can view which reports, but those decisions are combined with foundational and shared operational checks before access is granted. This application policy managed the service's own requirements, but it did so in coordination with the foundational and shared operational layers. A finance employee could view a report only if their device met security standards and if no shared operational rule restricted access based on time, location, or workflow state.

Together, these policies established a unified access-control model that aligned with ACME's zero-trust security architecture. Application teams retained control over their own logic, but foundational and shared operational policies enabled security and cross-team organizations to articulate requirements without altering application code. Since the policy engine evaluated all relevant policies collectively, each decision reflected both ACME's enterprise-wide requirements and the specific rules of the service being accessed.

This structure gave ACME a consistent and scalable way to manage access across the company. It prevented duplication of logic across applications, reduced the risk of policy drift over time, and aligned authorization with the organization's structure and governance model. With foundational, shared operational, and application policies working together, Zero Trust evolved from simply an architectural strategy to the everyday practice of how ACME protected its systems.